

SPQR Confidential: Power and Politics in the Roman Senate

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



High School Specialized Committee

Co-Chairs: Esha Madamalla and Bhavya Yendapalli

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

March 13th-14th, 2026

Dear Delegates,

It is with great anticipation that we welcome you to TechMUN XXXIII and SPQR Confidential: Power and Politics in the Roman Senate. This specialized committee places you at the heart of one of the most consequential political moments in ancient history. As senators of the Roman Republic, you will confront instability, ambition, and the looming possibility of civil war. The Republic stands at a crossroads, and its survival depends on your decisions.

Throughout this weekend, we expect thoughtful debate, strategic alliance-building, and speeches grounded in historical understanding and political creativity. This committee rewards delegates who fully embody their assigned roles and respond dynamically to unfolding crises. While the atmosphere may be intense, we encourage respectful discourse, bold ideas, and a willingness to take calculated risks. Whether this is your first conference or you are an experienced delegate, we hope you embrace the complexity of Roman politics and bring the Senate to life. If you have any questions, don't hesitate to email romansenatetechmun2026@gmail.com.

Senatus Populusque Romanus, the Senate and the People of Rome, now look to you.

Esha Madamalla & Bhavya Yendapalli

Co-Chairs, Roman Senate, 2025

Introduction to the Roman Senate

The Roman Senate was the central governing institution of the Roman Republic, composed primarily of aristocratic elites who wielded immense influence over legislation, foreign policy, military command, and state finances. Although technically advisory, the Senate functioned as the true engine of Roman political life. For centuries, Rome operated under a republican system built upon checks and balances, annual elections, and shared authority among magistrates. Power was intentionally divided between consuls, tribunes, praetors, and the Senate in order to prevent tyranny.

However, Rome's rapid territorial expansion across the Mediterranean transformed it from a city-state into a sprawling empire. This expansion brought extraordinary wealth and military prestige, but it also introduced structural strain. Wealth inequality widened dramatically, corruption became more visible, and political competition intensified. Generals returning from successful campaigns commanded not only glory but also the loyalty of seasoned legions. Over time, allegiance shifted from the Republic itself to individual commanders, creating dangerous precedents.

By the first century BCE, the Republic faced unprecedented internal pressure. Reform attempts, including those of the Gracchi brothers, ended in violence. The dictatorship of Sulla demonstrated that Roman armies could be turned against Rome itself. Now, powerful figures such as Julius Caesar and Pompey Magnus dominate political life, and the Senate must decide whether it can maintain authority in the face of personal ambition and military power.

Topic A: Preserving the Roman Republic

Background

For nearly five centuries, the Roman Republic maintained a delicate balance between competing institutions. Consuls were elected annually to prevent the consolidation of executive authority. Tribunes represented the interests of the plebeians. The Senate provided continuity and long-term strategic oversight. This system, though imperfect, allowed Rome to expand and consolidate power while avoiding monarchy.

Yet expansion created unintended consequences. Conquered territories flooded Rome with wealth, enslaved labor, and economic inequality. Small landowners struggled as vast estates controlled by elites dominated agricultural production. Political offices became pathways to wealth and influence rather than civic duty. Electoral bribery and patronage networks intensified factionalism within the Senate.

In response to growing inequality, reformers sought redistribution of land and expanded representation. However, resistance from conservative senators led to violence and political assassinations. The Republic increasingly relied on emergency powers, including the appointment of dictators during crises. While originally temporary and limited, these powers set a precedent for the concentration of authority. The rise of charismatic leaders capable of commanding popular support further destabilized traditional norms.

Current Situation

The Republic now faces an existential threat. Julius Caesar's military success in Gaul has elevated him to unprecedented popularity among both soldiers and citizens. His crossing of the

Rubicon River in defiance of senatorial orders represents a direct challenge to Senate authority. Civil war either looms or has already begun, depending on the precise starting point of this committee.

Within the Senate, factions are deeply divided. Some senators argue that extraordinary times require extraordinary leadership and believe that empowering a single strong figure may restore stability. Others insist that granting such power would dismantle the very foundations of the Republic. Trust between institutions has eroded, and compromise appears increasingly difficult.

The Senate must determine whether reform can preserve the Republic or whether structural change is inevitable. Every decision carries consequences that may define Rome's future for centuries.

Possible Solutions

Preserving the Republic may require strengthening traditional safeguards, including stricter enforcement of term limits and clearer separation between military command and political office. Structural reforms aimed at reducing economic inequality and corruption could address the underlying grievances fueling instability. Alternatively, the Senate may consider formalizing expanded executive authority in the interest of stability, though such a move risks transforming Rome into an autocratic state. Each path offers potential stability but also profound danger.

Questions to Consider

- Is the Roman Republic still capable of governing an empire of this scale?
- Should loyalty to Rome outweigh loyalty to powerful generals?
- Do emergency powers preserve the Republic, or do they erode it?

- Can meaningful reform occur without violence?

Helpful Links

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Roman_Senate
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Roman_Republic
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Conflict_of_the_Orders
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lucius_Cornelius_Sulla
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Julius_Caesar
- <https://origins.osu.edu/read/julius-caesar-crosses-rubicon>



Topic B: The Rise of Military Power and Personal Armies

Background

The Roman army was once composed of citizen-soldiers who returned to civilian life after campaigns. However, military reforms in the late Republic allowed landless citizens to enlist, transforming the structure of military service. Soldiers increasingly depended on their generals for land grants, compensation, and advancement. As a result, loyalty shifted away from the Senate and toward individual commanders.

This shift dramatically altered the political landscape. Generals such as Marius, Sulla, Pompey, and Caesar demonstrated that military force could directly influence political outcomes. Marching on Rome, once unthinkable, became a reality. Civil conflict replaced institutional negotiation. Military prestige translated into political leverage, and political office became intertwined with battlefield success.

Current Situation

The Senate must now confront the reality that legions are stationed across the Republic's territories under the command of ambitious leaders. These armies are disciplined, experienced, and loyal to their generals. If disagreements escalate into conflict, military force may determine the Republic's fate.

The question is no longer whether the military influences politics, but whether civilian governance can survive its dominance. Some senators may seek compromise with powerful commanders in order to maintain stability. Others may attempt to restrict military authority

through legislation or political maneuvering. However, enforcement remains uncertain when backed by armed force.

The balance between tradition and power has never been more fragile.

Possible Solutions

The Senate could attempt to limit the duration of provincial commands and require stricter oversight of military movements. Separating military authority from political office may restore institutional balance. Negotiated power-sharing agreements might temporarily ease tensions, though they risk legitimizing personal rule. Alternatively, the Senate may decide that centralizing authority under one leader is the only path to stability. Each solution requires careful calculation, as missteps could plunge Rome into prolonged civil war.

Questions to Consider

- Should military leaders be permitted to hold political office while commanding armies?
- How can the Senate prevent another march on Rome?
- Is compromise with powerful generals a sign of weakness or wisdom?
- What is more important: preserving Republican tradition or ensuring immediate stability?

Helpful Links

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Roman_army
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gaius_Marius
- <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pompey>
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Caesar%27s_civil_war

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/First_Triumvirate

Final Note

The fall of the Roman Republic was not a single event but a gradual erosion of norms, institutions, and trust. Ambition, fear, reform, and resistance all shaped its trajectory. As senators, your decisions will determine whether Rome remains a Republic or transitions into an Empire. The Senate is now in session.



Works Cited

- Kotva, Alyssa. "Julius Caesar Crosses the Rubicon | Origins." *Origins.osu.edu*, 7 Jan. 2024, origins.osu.edu/read/julius-caesar-crosses-rubicon. Accessed 7 Feb. 2026.
- Levick, Barbara. "Morals, Politics, and the Fall of the Roman Republic." *Greece & Rome*, vol. 29, no. 1, 1982, pp. 53–62, www.jstor.org/stable/642930. Accessed 7 Feb. 2026.
- Roselaar, Saskia T. "The Gracchi and the Privatization of Ager Publicus." *Oxford University Press EBooks*, 8 July 2010, pp. 221–289, academic.oup.com/book/3321/chapter/144368960?login=true, <https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199577231.003.0005>. Accessed 7 May 2024.
- Williams, Guy. *The Historiography of the Late Roman Republic*.
"Caesar's Civil War." Wikipedia, Wikimedia Foundation, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Caesar%27s_civil_war. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.
- "Conflict of the Orders." Wikipedia, Wikimedia Foundation, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Conflict_of_the_Orders. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.
- "First Triumvirate." Wikipedia, Wikimedia Foundation, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/First_Triumvirate. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.
- "Gaius Marius." Wikipedia, Wikimedia Foundation, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gaius_Marius. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.
- "Julius Caesar." Wikipedia, Wikimedia Foundation, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Julius_Caesar. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.

Dossier

1. **Gaius Julius Caesar (Dictator Perpetuo)**
Holds supreme authority in Rome after defeating all rivals in civil war. His unprecedented honors and lifelong dictatorship fuel fears he intends to become king.
2. **Marcus Antonius (Consul of Rome)**
Caesar's most trusted lieutenant and political enforcer. Commands loyalty among veterans and is central to protecting Caesar from both political and physical threats.
3. **Marcus Aemilius Lepidus (Master of the Horse)**
Second only to Caesar in formal authority and controls troops near Rome. Publicly loyal but quietly hedging his future.
4. **Marcus Junius Brutus (Praetor)**
A celebrated noble descended from Rome's founders. Privately conflicted between loyalty to Caesar and devotion to republican liberty.
5. **Gaius Cassius Longinus (Senator and Former General)**
A hardened soldier embittered by Caesar's dominance. Actively organizing resistance among Rome's elite.
6. **Decimus Junius Brutus Albinus (Governor-Designate of Cisalpine Gaul)**
One of Caesar's most trusted generals and a close confidant. His proximity to Caesar grants him unique influence—and opportunity.
7. **Publius Servilius Casca (Tribune of the Plebs)**
An outspoken critic of Caesar's monarchical honors. Believes immediate action is necessary to save the Republic.
8. **Gaius Trebonius (Senator and Former Legate)**
A skilled administrator who owes his career to Caesar. Increasingly uneasy about Caesar's absolute power.
9. **Lucius Tillius Cimber (Senator)**
Recently denied a political favor by Caesar. Uses personal grievance to justify opposition.
10. **Servius Sulpicius Galba (Senator)**
An aristocrat with a family history of resistance to strongmen. Quietly aligning with anti-Caesarian elements.
11. **Marcus Tullius Cicero (Orator and Statesman)**
Rome's greatest living speaker and defender of republican ideals. Politically isolated but intellectually influential.
12. **Quintus Fufius Calenus (Senator)**
A committed Caesarian and ally of Antony. Works to legitimize Caesar's authority through the Senate.
13. **Lucius Calpurnius Piso Caesoninus (Pontifex and Senator)**
Caesar's father-in-law and a respected elder. Advocates compromise and fears civil war above all else.

14. Gaius Octavius (Caesar's Grandnephew)

A young noble studying abroad, largely unknown in Roman politics. Named Caesar's heir (not yet publicly known), a fact that could alter the balance of power.

15. Titus Pomponius Atticus (Banker and Political Insider)

One of Rome's richest men and a close confidant of many senators. Maintains neutrality while financing both sides.

16. Calpurnia (Wife of Julius Caesar)

Well-connected aristocrat with access to private intelligence and omens. Increasingly alarmed by signs foretelling danger.

17. Servilia (Mother of Brutus)

A matron of immense prestige and political memory. Exerts subtle influence over elite opinion and family loyalties.

18. Lucius Munatius Plancus (General and Administrator)

A seasoned officer loyal to Caesar but ambitious in his own right. Watches events closely for opportunities.

19. Gaius Asinius Pollio (Officer and Historian)

An intellectual soldier aligned with Caesar. Balances ideological reflection with practical survival.

20. Sextus Pompeius (Naval Commander)

Son of Pompey the Great and still commanding loyal forces. Represents the lingering threat of Pompeian resistance.

21. Lucius Cornelius Balbus (Political Advisor)

Caesar's chief fixer and strategist. Controls access, information, and favors within Caesar's inner circle.

22. The College of Augurs (Religious Authority)

Interpreters of omens whose declarations can sway public opinion. Increasingly pressured to legitimize or condemn Caesar's rule.

23. Aulus Hirtius (Legate and Consul-Designate)

A seasoned officer and loyal Caesarian who commanded legions during the Gallic and Civil Wars. Personally indebted to Caesar for his rise and committed to preserving his legacy, though wary of open civil conflict.

24. Gaius Vibius Pansa Caetronianus (Legate and Consul-Designate)

A moderate Caesarian general with strong ties to the Senate. Supports Caesar's authority but believes reconciliation with republican elites is necessary to avoid renewed bloodshed.

25. Lucius Cornelius Dolabella (General and Political Opportunist)

A volatile and ambitious commander with shifting loyalties. Recently aligned with Caesar but known for personal ambition and radical populism, making him an unpredictable force in both military and political affairs.